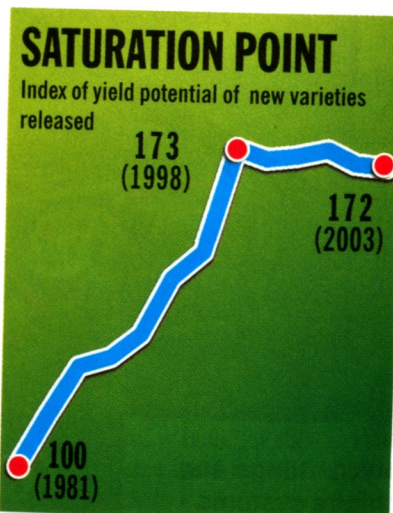


**SEEDS OF TROUBLE:** No hybrid varieties or technological breakthroughs have been made in recent years

Uttar Pradesh and Haryana have touched peak levels and in many zones are facing a decline. In Punjab the yield from one hectare has dropped from 4,700 to 4,000 kg a hectare in two decades. The decline is largely attributed to an "ageing" wheat variety WL 343, which has been in use since mid-'90s.

As a result, the country's wheat production has stagnated at around 70 million tonne even during the best of years and recently even lagged behind targets. Last year, as prices of food shot up, the Government signalled its intent of importing 15 million tonne to make up for the shortfall. This year, a group of ministers has already recommended that the country import 5 million tonne of wheat to tide over any possible shortage.

Yields of other foodgrains too have stagnated. In the major rice-growing states of West Bengal, Uttar



## TECHNOLOGY FATIGUE

**FOR MANMOHAN SINGH, THE ONE FEATURE that truly stands out is the "lack of any technological breakthrough in agricultural production technology in recent years."** There has been no technological breakthrough in either high-yielding varieties or hybrid seeds that could match the quantum jump in yields similar to that effected by the introduction of the Mexican dwarf variety of wheat in the mid-1960s. The Green Revolution and the self-sufficiency in foodgrains it resulted in is running out of steam. Green Revolution 2.0 is nowhere close to development leave alone introduction.

Yields in the major wheat-growing states of Punjab,

Pradesh and Punjab, yields have hovered at around 1,900 kg per hectare. Yields of pulses have reached a plateau at around 550 kg per hectare and the total production has not exceeded 14 million tonne. A new high-yielding variety is being introduced, but it will take a while to stabilise. With demand for pulses pegged at around 18 million tonne, India has become the world's largest importer of the commodity. In oilseeds, though India has doubled its production in the past two decades to 26 million tonne, increased consumption as a result of higher incomes has led to a shortfall of 8 million tonne, necessitating a constant flow of imports, taking India's agriculture import bill to Rs 22,000 crore last year. But with exports of rice and other

**15% fall in wheat yields in Punjab because of overuse of land.**